

DIY Fodder System for Livestock

What Is Fodder?

Fodder refers to sprouted seeds (usually barley or wheat) grown hydroponically. The entire sprout, including seed and root mat, is fed to animals. It takes 6-8 days to grow and is nearly 100% digestible.

Pros & Cons

Advantages:

- Nearly 100% digestible
- Fast growth: 6-8 days
- Great seed-to-feed ratio (5 lb seed = 25 lb fodder)
- Fresh, nutrient-rich, and low waste

Considerations:

- Requires consistent soaking, draining, and rinsing
- Not a complete feed; works best as a supplement
- Needs climate control in extreme weather

Materials Needed

- Clean barley or wheat seed
- Plastic trays with drain holes
- Racks or PVC shelving
- Buckets for soaking
- Water source for rinsing
- Optional: diluted bleach for sanitizing trays

Step-by-Step Process

Day 0 - Soaking:

- Soak seeds in clean water for 12-24 hours, then drain well.

Days 1-2 - Sprouting:

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- Spread soaked seeds in trays. Place in a ventilated area with light.
- Drain excess water daily.

Days 3-5 - Growing:

- Rinse and mist seeds 2x daily.
- Allow green blades to emerge; ensure air circulation.

Day 6 or 7 - Harvest:

- Fodder should be 3-6" tall. Feed it directly to livestock.

Daily Rotation:

- Start new trays daily so one batch is ready each day.

Feeding Guidelines & Maintenance

- Feed ~1-2% of animal's body weight per day
- Rinse trays after use
- Sanitize trays periodically with diluted bleach
- Reuse rinse water for garden irrigation if clean

Daily Timeline Summary

Day 0: Soak seeds for 12-24 hours

Days 1-2: Drain and spread seeds in trays

Days 3-5: Rinse/mist 2x daily

Day 6/7: Harvest and feed

Repeat daily with staggered trays